Jatavs too are very significant and are important for all political parties in these dozen seats, so if a large chunk votes unitedly, it could change the election narrative. If the Gujjars, Yadavs and some OBC communities also support the same party, then the combination could be a big challenge to the ruling BJP."

The RLD had been in the wilderness since the 2014 general election, when the Jats shifted allegiance to the BJP, a direct fallout of the 'Jat vs Muslim' schisms created after the 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots. The party had been reduced to a single seat in the 2017 assembly election; it won eight in the 2022 edition, mostly due to the work put in by Jayant, especially during the anti-farm law protests. Now with the victory in Khatauli, it has nine seats.

In 2021, Jayant came up with the 'Bhaichara zindabad' campaign to try and bridge the gap between Jats and the other sections including Muslims, Dalits and other weaker sections. This also involved creating a socio-cultural platform for poetry and drama performances, as also discussions on contemporary topics, which went a long way in bringing together the different groups. Many of the events were delayed due to Covid but after the assembly polls in February 2022, the RLD had restarted the campaign covering all the districts of western UP. "People won't always vote on the same Hindu-Muslim agenda. Western UP is fed up with the hate politics of the BJP," says Jayant.

Meanwhile, state BJP chief and western UP native Bhupendra Chaudhary feels the new caste equations being spun by Jayant won't work in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. "We accept the defeat in Khatauli but the kind of narrative the SP-RLD-Bhim Army combine is spinning is not true. Bypolls always involve several local factors, the Lok Sabha election will be different," he says. ■



LACK OF ACCESSIBILITY HAS BEEN AN ENDEMIC ISSUE WITH THACKERAY SINCE HIS FORMAL ENTRY INTO POLITICS IN 1990

"reward economy" mechanism by ensuring that material benefits accrued from the control over the BMC trickle down to the cadre.

In Mumbai, Thackeray's Shiv Sena is sniffing a political opening on issues that may help polarise voters on grounds of linguistic and regional pride. It includes the "injustice" perpetrated on Maharashtra by depriving it of investments like the Rs 1.54 lakh crore Vedanta-Foxconn semiconductor plant, which has chosen to drop anchor in Gujarat instead.

The Shiv Sena claims that the BJP-led Union government is being partial to Gujarat at the cost of Maharashtra and wants to sever Mumbai from Maharashtra. It projects the state government as the client regime of the Centre.

Any linguistic polarisation in the BMC polls may help the party hold on to its core Marathi voters. The issue of Mumbai being severed from Maharashtra has a strong emotional connection for Maharashtrians and has been used successfully by the Shiv Sena to bolster its electoral fortunes (1985 and 2012).

Abhay Deshpande, senior journalist and political commentator, says that Thackeray had no option but to increase his public presence after the massive setback to his party. "Thackeray has to prevent any fence-sitters from leaving. It is obvious that for this, he has to play on the front foot," he observes.

However, a senior Shiv Sena worker notes that Thackeray had similarly changed his style of functioning in the past after Rane and Raj Thackeray's revolts (2005), which posed a major threat to the party. "But after the crisis blew over, it was back to square one," he laments.

For decades, Thackeray has been seen as being surrounded by a coterie which controls access to him. As the chief minister of Maharashtra for two-and-a-half years, he was blamed for being inaccessible to his ministers and legislators, preferring to operate from his residence rather than his sixth-floor office in the state administrative headquarters of Mantralaya. Indeed, when he visited Mantralaya in April this year, it became a story in itself! The BJP, which was then in the opposition, had attacked his absence from office.

His aides then had pointed out that Thackeray (61), who underwent an angioplasty in 2012, had merely followed physical distancing norms during the Covid-19 pandemic. He had also undergone spine surgery in 2021. Later, he found it difficult to bend his neck, which has been affecting his movements.

Despite this, Shiv Sena insiders admit that lack of accessibility has been an endemic issue with Thackeray since his formal entry into politics in April 1990. Till he took over as the party working president in January 2003, and by extension as the political heir of his father, the late Shiv Sena supremo Bal Thackeray, he operated more as a backroom strategist, preferring it to the hurly-burly of the Sena's street-level politics. ■